NOTE: It is important to keep the air intake opening clear of debris. Leaf particles and other debris that is small enough to pass through the cowl opening screen can accumulate within the HVAC housing. The closed, warm, damp and dark environment created within the housing is ideal for the growth of certain molds, mildews and other fungi. Any accumulation of decaying plant matter provides an additional food source for fungal spores, which enter the housing with the fresh intake-air. Excess debris, as well as objectionable odors created by decaying plant matter and growing fungi can be discharged into the passenger compartment during heater-A/C operation if the air intake opening is not kept clear of debris.

The A/C system on models so equipped is designed for the use of non-CFC, R-134a refrigerant and uses an A/C fixed orifice tube located in the liquid line to meter the flow of refrigerant to the A/C evaporator. The A/C evaporator cools and dehumidifies the incoming air prior to blending it with the heated air. To maintain minimum evaporator temperature and prevent evaporator freezing, the A/C clutch is cycled on and off by the A/C low pressure switch mounted on the accumulator.

DIAGNOSIS AND TESTING

A / C PERFORMANCE

The A/C system is designed to provide the passenger compartment with low temperature and low humidity air. The A/C evaporator, located in the HVAC housing is cooled to temperatures near the freezing point. As warm damp air passes over the fins of the A/C evaporator, the air transfers its heat to the refrigerant in the evaporator coils and the moisture in the air condenses on the evaporator fins. During periods of high heat and humidity, an A/C system will be more effective in the Recirculation mode (max-A/C). With the system in the Recirculation mode, only air from the passenger compartment passes through the A/C evaporator. As the passenger compartment air dehumidifies, the A/C system performance levels rise.

Humidity has an important bearing on the temperature of the air delivered to the interior of the vehicle. It is important to understand the effect that humidity has on the performance of the A/C system. When humidity is high, the A/C evaporator has to perform a double duty. It must lower the air temperature, and it must lower the temperature of the moisture in the air that condenses on the evaporator fins. Condensing the moisture in the air transfers heat energy into the evaporator fins and coils. This reduces the amount of heat the A/C evaporator can absorb from the air. High humidity greatly reduces the ability of the A/C evaporator to lower the temperature of the air.

However, evaporator capacity used to reduce the amount of moisture in the air is not wasted. Wringing some of the moisture out of the air entering the vehicle adds to the comfort of the passengers. Although, an owner may expect too much from their A/C system on humid days. A performance test is the best way to determine whether the system is performing up to design standards. This test also provides valuable clues as to the possible cause of trouble with the A/C system. The ambient air temperature in the location where the vehicle will be tested must be a minimum of 21° C (70° F) for this test.

A / C PERFORMANCE TEST

WARNING: Refer to the applicable warnings and cautions for this system before performing the following operation (Refer to 24 - HEATING & AIR CONDITIONING/PLUMBING - WARNINGS) and (Refer to 24 - HEATING & AIR CONDITIONING/PLUMBING - CAUTIONS). Failure to follow the warnings and cautions could result in possible personal injury or death.

NOTE: When connecting the service equipment coupling to the line fitting, verify that the valve of the coupling is fully closed. This will reduce the amount of effort required to make the connection.

(1) Check for diagnostic trouble codes using a scan tool. If no DTCs are found in the powertrain control module (PCM), go to Step 2. If any DTCs are found, repair as required, then proceed to Step 2.

(2) Connect a tachometer and a manifold gauge set or an A/C recycling/charging station.

(3) Operate the heating-A/C system under the following conditions.

- Engine at 1,000 rpm at operating temperature
- Doors or windows open
- Transmission in Park or Neutral with parking brake set (depending on application)
- A/C-heater controls set to Recirculation mode (max-A/C), full cool, panel mode, high blower and with A/C compressor engaged. If the A/C compressor does not engage, see the A/C System Diagnosis chart.

(4) Insert a thermometer in the driver side center panel air outlet and operate the A/C system until the thermometer temperature stabilizes.

(5) The A/C clutch may cycle, depending upon the ambient temperature and humidity. If the A/C clutch cycles, disconnect the wire harness connector from the A/C low pressure switch located on the top of the accumulator and install a jumper wire across the terminals of the wire harness connector (Fig. 3).